

ESCP Business School

Affiliate Professor Marketing

Gustavo Garcia Mansilla

BACHELOR'S THESIS

Thesis submitted in partial fulfilment of the
requirements for the degree of Bachelor of Science
(B.Sc.)

The Role of Social Media in Enhancing Fan Engagement for Tennis Brands: A Comparative Study of Nike and Adidas

Supervisor: Gustavo Garcia

Author: Mattéo Laurent
9 rue Jacques Éléonor
Ferme, Colombes 92 700,
France
E211080
05/05/2025

Abstract

The purpose of this thesis is to investigate how social media works as a tool for increasing fan engagement for sports brands with a niche focus on tennis and leader in the industry Nike and Adidas. Then there are social media platforms — Instagram, TikTok, Twitter — that have fundamentally altered the way sports brands connect with fans, providing new means through which to engage audiences through customization, interactive features and real-time broadcasting.

This thesis investigates two core questions:

1. *How do Nike and Adidas construct digital storytelling frameworks—through athlete personas, tournament narratives, and heritage campaigns—to foster emotional loyalty among tennis fans?*

2. *Which social media platforms and content formats drive the highest engagement for tennis brands, and how do algorithmic biases and fan behaviours shape these outcomes?*

This study takes a qualitative and comparative approach, with case studies of successful campaigns in the tennis sector for Nike and Adidas in digital marketing. It will evaluate audience metrics, brand initiatives and fan engagement around the world. We will also leverage data from industry reports, social media analytics, and academic literature to determine how effective social media channels are compared to traditional marketing systems.

Through looking at the implications of social media on your fan engagement and product advertising, this research aims to seek to further understand how digital networks have really emerged as vital in shaping the up-to-date sports brand experience.

2. Table of Contents

1. INTRODUCTION 5

2. LITERATURE REVIEW 10

2.1. THEORETICAL BACKGROUND ON FAN ENGAGEMENT 10
2.1.1. MODELS OF EMOTIONAL LOYALTY: PSYCHOLOGICAL AND RELATIONAL FOUNDATIONS 10
2.1.2. PERSONALIZED AND INTERACTIVE MARKETING IN THE SPORT CONTEXT 11
2.2. DIGITAL STORYTELLING IN SPORTS: THE CASE OF TENNIS 12
2.2.1 TENNIS AS A DISTINCTIVE MEDIA SPORT: INDIVIDUALITY AND INTIMACY 12
2.2.2 EMOTIONAL ENGAGEMENT THROUGH STAR POWER 13
2.2.3 TOURNAMENT-DRIVEN NARRATIVES AND RHYTHMIC ENGAGEMENT 13
2.3 THE ROLE OF BRANDS IN THE TENNIS ECOSYSTEM: POSITIONING OF NIKE AND ADIDAS 14
2.3.1 STRATEGIC FOCUS: APPAREL AND IDENTITY OVER EQUIPMENT 14
2.3.2 ALIGNMENT WITH MAJOR TOURNAMENTS AND GLOBAL VISIBILITY 15
2.3.3 MARKETING OBJECTIVES AND TARGET AUDIENCES 15
2.4 PLATFORM-SPECIFIC SOCIAL MEDIA STRATEGIES 15
2.4.1 EFFECTIVE CONTENT FORMATS AND THE RISE OF INTERACTIVITY 16

3. METHODOLOGY 16

3.1 RESEARCH DESIGN AND JUSTIFICATION 16
3.1.1 CASE SELECTION: NIKE AND ADIDAS 18
3.2 DATA COLLECTION METHODS 18
3.2.1 SECONDARY DATA COLLECTION 18
3.2.2 PRIMARY DATA COLLECTION 19
3.3 DATA ANALYSIS 21

4. RESULTS: NIKE AND ADIDAS: CONSTRUCTING EMOTIONAL LOYALTY THROUGH DIGITAL STORYTELLING 22

4.1 THE LEGENDS ERA: FEDERER, NADAL OF NIKE 22
4.1.1 THE TRANSITION: CARLOS ALCARAZ AND THE NEW GENERATION 23
4.2 ADIDAS: THE REBELS AND THE PROGRESSIVES 24
4.2.1 THE RISE OF RELATABLE ICONS 24
4.3 TOURNAMENT MYTHMAKING: ELEVATING TENNIS INTO CULTURAL NARRATIVES 25
4.3.1 WIMBLEDON: THE TEMPLE OF TRADITION 25
4.3.2 ROLAND-GARROS: THE CULT OF GRIT 26
4.3.3 US OPEN: URBAN ENERGY AND SOCIAL CONSCIENCE 26
4.3.4 AUSTRALIAN OPEN: THE LAB OF INNOVATION 27

4.4 RESULTS: SOCIAL MEDIA PLATFORMS & CONTENT FORMATS: WHAT DRIVES ENGAGEMENT? 28

4.4.1 PLATFORM PERFORMANCE ANALYSIS 28
4.4.2 FORMAT & CONTENT TYPE EFFECTIVENESS 29
4.4.3 ALGORITHMIC BIASES & FAN BEHAVIOUR PATTERNS 30

5. DISCUSSION 31

5.1 OBSERVATION & KEY FINDINGS FROM INTERVIEW WITH GINEVRA 31
5.2 SURVEY RESULTS: EXPLORING FAN ENGAGEMENT AND PERCEPTIONS OF TENNIS BRAND STRATEGIES ON SOCIAL MEDIA 32

CONCLUSION 35

BIBLIOGRAPHY 38

APPENDIX 39

1. Introduction

In today’s digitally oriented world, social media changed how brands engage with their audience—Especially in sports, where fan engagement is important for victory. Tennis, a sport with a worldwide yet exclusive following, presents a prominent challenge for brands like Nike and Adidas: how to fascinate many fans in an oversaturated digital landscape. Along with over 4.9billion social media users worldwide (Data Reportal 2024), platforms like Instagram; TikTok; and X have turned into indispensable tools for encouraging real-time connections as well as driving loyalty in addition to increasing product launches. The question is no longer whether brands should leverage social media, but rather how they can greatly optimize it to deepen fan relationships.

The thesis explores the transformative role in the digital platforms reshaping tennis marketing. It is offering understandings valuable to sports brands and to marketers navigating the intersection of technology and Tennis world. The ATP (the Association of Tennis Professionals) and the WTA (Women's Tennis Association) aim for gen z to catch their interest via social media are now a key for beating rivals.

The meaning of social media goes well beyond mere communication, reaching a status of fundamental brand strategy for sports because of its power to construct authentic narratives and cultivate emotional connections with audiences around the world. For sports brands, the art and science of digital engagement have become central to the increasingly intricate puzzle of fan emotional loyalty. The perceptions that fans hold of you can practically determine what your brand is, how they'll interact with you, and even dictate the conditions under which they'll step into your world as a consumer.

Tennis is especially interesting to analyse since it blends tradition and innovation in a way that appeals to a set of demographics ranging from Baby Boomers to Millennials and especially to the Gen Z population that's growing up with a phone in each hand. Within the tennis digital space, Nike and Adidas are digital kings. Both are powerful brands that have a commanding presence across all relevant digital platforms that tennis fans inhabit.

While existing work rigorously studies social media's effect upon fan involvement within major sports such as football and basketball, is not really study within tennis industry since it is less followed than the other sports cited by gen Z. Tennis is a sport possessing special spectator demographics plus usage trends—is still unexplored. Many of the studies stress broad social media strategies (Hutchins & Rowe, 2012) or focus on mass-appeal leagues, often overlooking niche markets where the personalized engagement is important. Also, even though some research says that speaking fast is good (Kassing et al., 2020), few studies see how to act on each place (like TikTok's short clips to others). Twitter's talking threads helped start fan faithfulness. It helped in a way that could be figured out. This issue is vital since tennis firm should face a fragmented digital world were youth desire honesty and involvement. This study shows the relationship of social media in sports marketing strategies. By examining Nike's and Adidas' tennis ads via detailed comparisons, giving several useful tips for brands in Tennis markets.

Extensive previous research covers how high-profile sports transformed marketing and fan engagement strategies on social media. It explored broader phenomena such as collective identity, global fan communities, and athlete-celebrity interactions *(Abeza et al., 2019*. However, it hasn't focused on how tennis—"a globally influential and culturally distinctive sport," as our authors term it—interacts with fans to craft court-side experiences on social media.

That's a significant oversight because tennis is such a unique sport.
It's a largely individualistic sport (boxers, golfers, and tennis players often fly much higher in the win-loss satisfaction quotient than basketball, football, and baseball team players).
And this is not just about beating up on team sports.
Athlete branding in tennis, much more than in team sports, sings sweet songs to the ear of fan dynamics because there is almost always a hero and a villain on the tennis court, and these characters shift sides during the match at crisis moments.

This thesis investigates two core questions:

1. *How do Nike and Adidas construct digital storytelling frameworks—through athlete personas, tournament narratives, and heritage campaigns—to foster emotional loyalty among tennis fans?*

2. *Which social media platforms and content formats drive the highest engagement for tennis brands, and how do algorithmic biases and fan behaviours shape these outcomes?*

These two connected questions strategically pick apart the intersection of brand strategy, platform dynamics, and fan psychology in tennis's digital ecosystem. They allow a comprehensive analysis of that ecosystem from the perspective of tennis brands and their audiences.

This research uses a qualitative, multi method to analyse the relation between brand strategy and platform dynamics in tennis world. With leveraging case study analysis, it examines into Nike as well as Adidas' digital campaigns (e.g., Roland-Garros activations, athlete partnerships) through secondary data: social media metrics (engagement rates, shares, sentiment analysis), brand reports, and press coverage. To map storytelling frameworks along with platform efficacy. A comparative content analysis across Instagram, TikTok, and Twitter posts should identify many general patterns. It should also identify many natural algorithmic biases in format performance. Primary data from select expert interview with sport marketers will properly contextualize into findings while thematic coding on fan comments fully decodes into emotional loyalty triggers. This date triangulation assures Vigor, furthermore, it links certain observed tendencies as well as tactical understanding.

A qualitative case study approach is adopted for this study. In order to achieve the aims and objectives of the study, it is a very appropriate methodology. This is because the case study design allows for an in-depth examination of complex social interactions with a focus on

real-life contexts. As this research seeks to evaluate brand communication as it interacts with fans in many different social environments, this is particularly important. There are many different case study formats. However, this research primarily relies on the single case study format. Two different units of analysis (Nike and Adidas) are employed for this case.

Data was gathered from relevant secondary sources including a plethora of different analytics derived directly from the social media platforms used by the two different brands (audience engagement rates, direct follower/fan interactions, and several different sentiment analysis tools).

A considerable amount of "thick description" (Geertz, 1973) has also been employed from the different brand documents produced by the two different brands. Similarly, relevant media reports have also been used to fill in this thick narrative description of the different branding techniques used by the two different brands *(Creswell & Poth, 2018)*.

This study furthers sport marketing concepts via linking the gap between digital storytelling systems and platform-specific engagement strategies in niche sports. By analysing how algorithmic biases interact with fan psychology, it offers a news lens for understanding emotional loyalty in the attention economy. This will help for future studies on Gen- Z audiences. For the practitioners, the findings provide a playbook for the tennis brands. Also, the findings come along with actionable understandings upon optimizing the content formats (e.g., TikTok myths vs. Instagram heritage posts), in addition to a way of leveraging real-time data for the purpose of increasing campaigns. For marketers, these results can apply to allocate sufficient budgets tactically, ensuring resonance across a fragmented digital landscape.

Theoretical perspectives. This thesis adds significantly to existing knowledge by integrating concepts of digital storytelling, emotional branding, and media ecology. Digital storytelling theory teaches us about the power of narratives such as athlete personas and heritage-focused campaigns to create millions of meaningful emotional bonds between sports fans

and the teams for which they cheer (Thomson et al., 2005). Meanwhile, media ecology provides a framework for understanding how our digital platforms mold us, as fans, into ever-more-engaged supporters through unique communication formats and algorithmic structures (Postman, 2000). By combining these two powerful theoretical perspectives, this study offers a sophisticated analysis of what kinds of stories sports brands can tell to achieve the digital engagement and fan loyalty that are the holy grails of modern sports marketing.

This thesis is intended to systematically handle the questions in the three major phases. The Literature Review is what establishes first the complete theoretical foundation. Platform-specific engagement of such dynamics along with the existing body of work on digital storytelling in sports marketing are thoroughly examined. To contextualize each of the digital strategies of sports brands, it provides for a thorough overview. Emotional branding, narrative transportation, and media ecology are each of the theoretical frameworks that are used in this overview.

Subsequently, the Methodology elucidates a particular qualitative tactic, thorough content analysis structures, plus case study choice, and intensive interview procedures created to analyse Adidas' and Nike's plans. This chapter clearly outlines a rationale for choosing one qualitative multi-method design since case studies strongly capture certain complex brand phenomena. The procedures for thematic coding plus content analysis are discussed thoroughly along with data collection methods—including social media analytics, brand reports, and expert interviews. The Findings section—organized by brand narratives in (Q1) as well as platform performance for (Q2)— systematically presents empirical understandings, as detailed analyses gathered understandings from Nike and Adidas' digital storytelling campaigns and platform-specific engagement metrics. These couple brands have several key differences and similarities highlighted. Narrative strategies that are distinct and content formats both generate emotional loyalty among all the fans.

Fan psychology along with algorithmic biases are the ways that the Discussion interprets at patterns. Certain theoretical lenses discussed earlier in the Literature Review are used to critically evaluate the empirical findings here. A relatively deep understanding of this chapter links the data to many theories about fan engagement, narrative effectiveness and

platform dynamics. This matrix serves as a practical tool for tennis brands to effectively measure, optimise and strategically align their digital narratives and platform choices. In addition, the conclusion clearly outlines the limitations of the current research and suggests concrete future avenues, such as deeper investigations into emerging platforms or the evolving fan engagement behaviours of different demographic groups, particularly Generation Z.

2. Literature Review

2.1. Theoretical Background on Fan Engagement

Engagement with fans refers to the many forms of interaction and connection that organizations and brands in the world of sports try to forge with the audiences they reach. Yes, these are audiences that, in some respects, can be considered mere viewers, but even in this context, the act of viewing may nonetheless contain some spectatorial approximation of seeing a game live. And there are, of course, viewers who act as superfans: those who watch every game and might also go to games or buy some team gear.

Fans used to only show their support when they were physically present, but now they can engage with content from anywhere. Virtual spaces allow for banding together across great distances, and even for some conflation of time and space. They allow for a kind of digital intimacy that is very much online, but somehow still feels personal. And fans now have many more opportunities to engage because there is a lot more content to engage with.

2.1.1. Models of Emotional Loyalty: Psychological and Relational Foundations

Fan engagement has a core constituent, which is emotional loyalty. This differs significantly in nature and essence from behavioural loyalty, which is the result of sticking with what one is used to or what one has been incentivized to do. What makes emotional loyalty so powerful is that it is about one’s identity—what one considers to be meaningful. Several theoretical models offer insight into what makes this bond so special and so strong.

- Customer-Brand Relationship Theory (Fournier, 1998) focuses on the emotional connections that forms when consumers perceive a brand as part of their self-concept. This emotional connection is especially visible in sports fandom, where identification with a team or athlete becomes part of one's personal identity.
- The psychology of fandom is based on the social identity theory (Tajfel & Turner, 1986). This theory states that people align themselves with certain brands or athletes to feel like they are part of something larger. Most fans never meet the people they idolize, so their bond is based on story, value, or experience. Or all three. If not, what kind of fandom would it be?
- Marketing's attachment Theory proposes that fans forge long-lasting emotional connections to brands. They do this, especially, when the content that a brand puts out trigger's feelings of nostalgia, admiration, or empowerment.

These emotional dynamics are amplified in the context of sports brands. Long-term engagement and brand supporter stem from emotional loyalty. This can manifest, for instance, as a kid being inspired by a champion's journey in tennis, or a lifelong fan feeling an attachment to a brand's visual heritage.

2.1.2. Personalized and Interactive Marketing in the Sport Context

Today, fan engagement is primarily structured around interactivity. The new digital platforms allow for interaction among fans of all kinds, whether they are commenting on a show, voting for an actor in an awards contest, or influencing the outcome of the narrative (as in those campaign moments where fans help pick a player's outfit). These new platforms have naturally extended the participatory culture that Henry Jenkins (2006) identified with audiences today.

More and more, brands that operate in the sports world are embracing an individualized marketing approach. They are using algorithms to create a preferred content layer for each consumer and running geolocation-based campaigns during tournaments. They have also

taken to the storytelling medium, using data-driven narratives to text. These tactics allow marketers to create the perception of intimacy and relevance that is now the key driver of emotional engagement.

Additionally, it is what some scholars like to call 'emotional resonance' that interactive marketing tools-polls, Q&As, behind-the-scenes streams generate. And what is emotional resonance if not a genuine, affective reaction that moments in our always-on lives should elicit?

2.2. Digital Storytelling in Sports: The Case of Tennis

The psychological foundation for fan engagement may well be laid by emotional fidelity, but in the digital age, that loyalty is activated and sustained through digital storytelling. Today, platforms are not just more dynamic; they are also profoundly more personalized. The way brands tell stories (and the stories themselves) must now work even harder to create and cultivate a long-term connection with fans. Tennis offers a unique narrative terrain, as varied and adventurous as the sport itself. The narrative differs in significant and important ways from all the storylines founds in team sports. The emotional arcs in tennis are more powerful.

2.2.1 Tennis as a Distinctive Media Sport: Individuality and Intimacy

Football or basketball are focused on team loyalty, city-based identities and a logo to cheer up. In contrast tennis is a core individual sport "*You win or lose alone*". Matches around the singular psychology, the emotions, and the trajectories of one athlete. And that structure makes for even more personalized and emotionally immersive storytelling. Fans aren't just cheering for a logo, they're support a player who's during another act in the drama of a match lived in public: an act that's as much about the transcendent moments we look for in art as it is about the points, games, and sets that make up a win.

The intimate, real-time, even democratic storytelling qualities of the social media platform lend themselves perfectly to this format for presenting individual stories. A player's post-

match selfie, slow-motion clip of a key moment or behind-the-scenes locker room video can tell a story as emotionally charged and intimate as a full team highlight reel. And this level of storytelling intimacy makes tennis an even more fertile ground for brands looking to connect with their audiences.

2.2.2 Emotional Engagement Through Star Power

In the game of tennis, star athletes are not just a desirable add-on—they are the sport's very essence. When one thinks of tennis, one thing that naturally comes to mind almost immediately is the constellation of big names like Roger Federer, Rafael Nadal, and Novak Djokovic. Yes, these athletes are supreme in their craft, performing at a level very few can simulate, let alone reach. But their personal brands—that is to say, their star power—is what drives the emotional engagement of fans across the globe. Even the newer generation of players, like Alexander Zverev and Carlos Alcaraz, are rapidly becoming part of the story of tennis, one that is unfolding in real time.

This emotional dynamic affects how fans interact with branded content. An Instagram post with Nadal in Nike or Zverev in an Adidas recovery video will often get a huge emotional response—not because of any branding but because fans are primed to react, emotionally, to what these two represent. In a way, the athlete becomes the story's main character, and digital platforms become the stage on which their stories are told.

2.2.3 Tournament-Driven Narratives and Rhythmic Engagement

Tennis derives a one-of-a-kind rhythm from having just four major Grand Slam events and a few other ATP/WTA tournaments in which to tell its story. Each tournament is a storytelling reset, complete with new settings, fresh stakes, and different emotional triggers. That makes it easy for brands to content-align with the tennis narrative and customize for the identity of each event—whether it’s the shuttered, intimate vibe of the Australian Open, the moving electric fanfare of the US Open, the sober beauty of the French Open, or the precision play of Wimbledon.

The fan-brand relationship is re-established with every tournament, just like in the episodic storytelling structure digital content strategies Favor. Each tournament becomes a new "season," allowing for simultaneous continuity and capitalizing on high visibility and emotionally charged moments. The big idea is to be where the audience is and to make what you're doing matter in relation to the audience's life whether that's through an engagement on a high level during a major event or questioning the very nature of existence in what might be called a "life stage."

2.3 The Role of Brands in the Tennis Ecosystem: Positioning of Nike and Adidas

Building on earlier discussions of emotional storytelling, it's important to understand how Nike and Adidas function within the larger tennis ecosystem. After all, they are far from traditional tennis brands like Wilson or Babolat, focused on technical equipment like racquets and strings. Instead, Nike and Adidas take a different approach: They make their presence felt in tennis through a combination of clothing, footwear, and partnerships with high-profile athletes.

2.3.1 Strategic Focus: Apparel and Identity over Equipment

Tennis racquets are not products of Nike and Adidas, nor are they sold by either company. The marketing dictates so. Neither brand has much interest in controlling the technical aspects of the game; they'd rather exert influence over its cultural and emotional narrative. With apparel and footwear, they do just that. Nike and Adidas are in the business of shaping visual identity and lifestyle (not to mention the on-court performance of their endorsers). And if you want to know how they do that, here are a few key incantations. When they center on performance wear, they become a facet of the athlete's story present in every high point of every match, every shot of the athlete on the podium, and every post on social media. This strategy allows for them to be a deeper part of the brand integration into the symbolic side of tennis, where what really counts is much more than just technical performance.

2.3.2 Alignment with Major Tournaments and Global Visibility

Nike and Adidas also command a strong presence at premier tournaments like Roland-Garros, Wimbledon, and the US Open—not as official sponsors of these events, but through their athlete ambassadors and campaign activations. The brands see their visibility greatly amplified at the Grand Slams, when the emotional peaks of the tennis calendar coincide with the largest international media focus. All the player's appearances in these events are carefully timed and heavily staged to act as the launching pads for new product lines.

2.3.3 Marketing Objectives and Target Audiences

Both brands work to resonate with younger, globally connected audiences, particularly Gen Z fans who engage with tennis via highlight clips, TikTok reels, and Instagram stories, rather than full matches. They're not simply targeting tennis enthusiasts; they're making tennis feel culturally relevant to the wider lifestyle communities' young people are part of. And in the Venn diagram where those communities meet sport, fashion, and storytelling, there's a lot of room for expressive overlap—"tennis is an elite pastime, yes, but also a dynamic sport that's alive with creative potential," say the voices of this new ecosystem.

2.4Platform-Specific Social Media Strategies

After integrating themselves into the tennis world through clothing, partnerships with athletes, and event-related visibility, Nike and Adidas use social media to reach tennis consumers more effectively. The two companies have taken very different paths in using social media.

TikTok, Instagram, Twitter/X: Algorithmic Dynamics and Engagement Mechanics

Each platform has its own rules concerning visibility and engagement. TikTok rewards virality with its short-form, high-energy videos. Instagram (now X/Threads) favors interaction with a suite of different features. Twitter/X conversation thrives on immediacy

and hot takes. All these platforms have their own set of algorithmic dynamics determining what content gets seen and by whom. A brand can tell the most powerful story in the world, but if it doesn't get seen, what does it matter?

2.4.1 Effective Content Formats and the Rise of Interactivity

Across all major platforms, the content format has become the 'dominant' one. Brands can quickly capture attention, maintain relevance and invite fan participation through reels, TikTok clips, Twitter threads and live sessions. The landscape is no longer driven by content, it's driven by getting involved. Blending emotional storytelling with algorithmic intelligence is the surest path to executional success when it comes to audience engagement in the digital space. The ideal participatory narrative is one that is structured in a way to rhythmically fit viewer expectations while also telling the kind of story that a brand needs told. By that I mean a brand narrative that is transformative, participatory, and empowering.

3. Methodology

3.1 Research Design and Justification

This thesis uses a qualitative and comparative research design. The aim is not simply to measure how many fans there are and how many times they interact with the tennis brands like Nike and Adidas but rather to support the simple question of why they do so and why they will continue to do so for the future.

As highlighted by various scholars working on sports marketing and social media (such as Abeza et al., 2019), qualitative inquiry is particularly valuable when exploring social processes like loyalty-building and community engagement, where context and interpretation are critical.

In the qualitative tradition, case study analysis was chosen as the predominant methodological approach. This focuses specifically on the brands Nike and Adidas, which have strong yet opposed positions in marketing tennis. It allows a real-world look at what these brands do and what the results are. The two case studies can be looked at comparably. That is fundamental because it helps not only to uncover what strategies these two marketing powerhouses deploy but also to see how radically different branding philosophies can lead to very different kinds of fan engagement across drastically different platforms and demographics.

According to Yin (2018), when a researcher is trying to understand something in a way that goes beyond the surface-level description and is asking themselves the questions of "how" and "why," then case studies are the kind of research method that fits best. This march perfectly the thesis objective to understand how brands storytelling in social platform will shape fan behaviour.

Finally, the choice of qualitative methods also answers a gap identified in previous research. Much of the literature on sports social media engagement focuses on major sports like football or basketball, where broad statistical measures dominate (Filo et al., 2015). By contrast, a qualitative, case-focused methodology allows this thesis to contribute uniquely to the **less-explored tennis marketing landscape**, where a more personalized, niche engagement style is required.

At last, using qualitative methods helps fill a gap identified in previous research. Most of the written work on sports social media engagement deals with the big-time sports, like football or basketball, and with them come broad, dominating measures of statistical significance (Filo et al., 2015). This thesis, using a qualitative, case-focused methodology, can engage in an exploration of social media for tennis, a sport whose marketing demands something more personalized and "niche" than does that of "major league" sports.

3.1.1 Case Selection: Nike and Adidas

Based on several criteria, Nike and Adidas were deliberately chosen to be the focus of this study. Both are global industry leaders, consistently ranked among the top brands for marketing innovation, athlete partnerships and sponsorship value. But beyond their market leadership, they represent two different aspirational models for brand storytelling in tennis.

Nike customarily stresses a heritage based as well as inspirational narrative. This emphasis further builds upon the very idea of sporting legends and lasting excellence. Campaigns with Roger Federer, Rafael Nadal, and emerging players like Carlos Alcaraz highlight perseverance, tradition, and transcendence. Adidas, in contrast, positions itself with inclusivity, innovation, and disruption. Campaigns that feature certain athletes such as Naomi Osaka or Stefanos Tsitsipas frequently challenge customary narratives, and they push themes such as mental health awareness, identity, and certain progressive values. Furthermore, tennis allows for a narrowed yet meaningful scope, as it focuses on a sport that is global, but with a demographic particularly sensitive to identity, prestige, and authenticity, all key elements that are in digital marketing strategies today.

3.2 Data Collection Methods

To collect meaningful data for this thesis, a multi-method strategy was employed, involving both secondary and primary sources. This method was chosen not just for its efficiency, it allows for a richness of data while ensuring cross-verification and reduction of bias.

3.2.1 Secondary Data Collection

Brand strategies and platform performance can objectively be mapped using secondary data. Several types of documents and datasets are needed:

Official Brand Publications: Press releases, marketing campaign overviews, and investor reports from Nike and Adidas.

Social Media Analytics: Information gathered using Hootsuite, as well as the analytics features that are native to each social media platform (for example, Instagram Insights,

TikTok for Business, and Twitter Analytics). This includes data on reach, engagement, and several other kinds of metrics.

Reports and Articles from the Industry: Publications from sources such as Marketing Week, Forbes, ATP Tour Reports, and specialized sports marketing journals.
Academic Literature: Key theories from digital marketing, sports branding, and algorithmic media studies (e.g., Hutchins & Rowe, 2012).

The secondary data collection process involves several steps:
Identifying Important Campaigns (2022–2025): Focusing on either Grand Slam tournaments or key athlete endorsements, each brand identifies its key tennis-related campaigns. Extraction of key metrics: Participation rate (liking, commenting, sharing), fan sentiment (positive, neutral, negative) and content format (reel, carousel, story).

Thematic Pattern Identification: The first step is to identify what are the dominant themes. Currently, we see such themes as nostalgia or innovation, rebellion or excellence, that make up the brand messaging and fan reactions.
Filo et al. (2015) and other scholars point out that the performance insights we get from secondary data particularly that from our digital interactions and behavioural signals that can be decoded through careful qualitative analysis.

3.2.2 Primary Data Collection

Only secondary data, despite its richness, may not fully disclose the strategic intentions behind certain campaigns or explain the subtle nuances of fan interpretation for a deeper understanding.

Primary data will be collected through two additional methods: Expert Interviews: A semi-structured interview was conducted as part of the primary data collection with Ginevra Capece Galeota, who is the Global Creative Partner at PWR House and a former

executive at Meta and Ogilvy. Given her vast experience in digital brand storytelling, she provided insights on how sports brands tailor their content strategies across platforms.

With extensive experience in digital brand storytelling, she shared insights into sports brands' cross-platform content strategies. She emphasised the need to choose platforms and content formats that match audience behaviour and algorithmic trends. She cited Nike and Adidas as examples of brands that have changed their style of communication not only to achieve their creative goals but also to drive data-driven performance. Ginevra also highlighted the specific challenge of engaging Gen Z audiences in tennis and stressed the need for inclusive and culturally relevant storytelling to break through the digital noise.

Her input helped to anchor the study in present-day industry practice, providing a standpoint from which view the intersection of strategy, creativity, and technology in contemporary sports marketing.

Sampling Fan Comments: Sample fan comments from key social media posts during major tennis tournaments like Roland Garros, Wimbledon, and the U.S. Open. Engaged, emotional comments, both loving and hating will be coded and reported.

Industry experts' external interpretations combine with brand-side strategies' triangulation as well as actual fan reactions. Triangulation often improves the credibility and validates findings, as qualitative research methods regularly stress (Creswell, 2013).

Student Survey: Concept and Purpose: The strategy for gathering primary data consisted of creating a brief online survey in Google Forms, for students between the ages of 18 and 25. The aim of the survey was to gain an initial understanding of what young social media users do when exposed to Nike and Adidas tennis material. The survey focused on 15-30 participants and combined closed and open-ended questions. Closed questions gathered information on platform usage, engagement habits and content preferences. Open-ended questions focused on brand storytelling and emotional connection. The format has been

chosen to gain an in-depth understanding of Gen Z, an important segment of the current tennis consumer.

3.3 Data Analysis

A combination of thematic coding and sentiment analysis will be used to analyze the data we have collected, following standard practices in qualitative content analysis.
Thematic Coding: The main method will be identifying recurring themes, patterns, and strategies across brand communications and fan responses. The codes will be inductively open coded from the data, then grouped into larger themes (i.e., any conceptual categories that might help organize the codes). The larger themes will be related to certain storytelling techniques (e.g., "heroism," "authenticity," "rebellion") and certain emotional drivers that could be involved (e.g., nostalgia, inspiration, controversy).

Sentiment Analysis: This part of the study is focused on fan comments and post reactions. For this, a standard positive/neutral/negative framework will be applied. While sentiment analysis is often associated with numbers and straightforward quantitative methods, in this study it serves as a way into deeper qualitative analysis. For instance, if a lot of people express negative sentiments about a certain post or comment, what does that mean in terms of narrative alignment or platform fit?

Data analysis will be conducted separately for each brand, followed by a comparative synthesis. Particular attention will be paid to:

- Variations across platforms (e.g., TikTok vs. Instagram vs. Twitter).
- Shifts over time (e.g., pre- and post-pandemic engagement trends).
- Audience segment reactions (e.g., Gen Z vs. older tennis fans).

As researchers such as Alaimo and Kallinikos (2022) suggest, to understand platform dynamics (algorithmic biases, content affordances). The thematic coding will then therefore focus in its part on platform-specific strategies. Nike's emphasis on storytelling reels on Instagram contrasts with Adidas' few experimental TikTok challenges.

The study aims for production of both depth and comparability by application of this dual analysis approach, to offer detailed brand understandings and broader implications for how tennis brands can optimize their social media strategies within a competitive digital environment.

4. Results: Nike and Adidas: Constructing Emotional Loyalty through Digital Storytelling

As we have already seen, Nike and Adidas have changed the marketing of tennis by linking it to a young, global audience. It's about creating emotional narratives that make tennis seem relevant, stylish and aspirational, rather than simply celebrating athletic achievement. With that in mind, let's look at the most basic and arguably best storytelling tool both brands use: their athletes. Through some very deliberate and quite different characterizations, each company makes its tennis players into figures of emotional loyalty. Nike and Adidas build emotional loyalty that transcends match results.

4.1 The Legends Era: Federer, Nadal of Nike

Federer, Nadal: The definite Legends Era. These athletes represent a sculpted archetype while monumental figures rose as Nike's golden tennis era occurred. Nike's golden era in tennis occurred during the time when the sport gained some genuinely iconic figures. Each of the figures typifies a persona of an athlete in which the Nike brand excels at.
Roger Federer the Poet of Tennis. An effortless artist. An elegant, precise, and nearly perfect machine of movement. The Nike campaigns that featured Federer mostly focus on the fact that he was both "*artistry"* and "*legacy"*. The campaigns projected Federer as almost untouchable with a tribute to his previous record at Wimbledon.
Rafael Nadal, in contrast, symbolize the Warrior Spirit. His storytelling narrative was grounded in pure physicality and relentless emotional drive. For Nadal, Nike constructed a visual identity that was as tough as the tennis he plays, full of dirt-streaked on clay at

Roland Garros, close-up imagery; slow-motion, clip of brutal rallies with sweat; and grittier music.

These two champions, or rather these two Nike legends, have left their mark on sport in general and are seen and imagined as sporting legends. In their time, they were the only two athletes to have a brand of clothing in collaboration with Nike in their effigy. This shows how much they were loved not only by tennis fans but also by sports fans in general, leading Nike to create collections specially dedicated to their image, recalling Michael Jordan's collection from Nike’s basketball greatest day.

4.1.1 The Transition: Carlos Alcaraz and the New Generation

With the emergence of Carlos Alcaraz, Nike is adapting its Legend formula to the new generation. Alcaraz is framed as the natural successor - a player who combines youthful spontaneity with echoes of the old guard's greatness. His digital portrayal often fuses clips of joyful play, hard training and big emotional moments (crying after winning a Grand Slam, for example).

Nike's "legend" formula sees an adaptation with the rise of Carlos Alcaraz. The young Spanish tennis star, who is possibly in line to become a future great, is today framed by the sportswear giant as the Natural Successor of the great Rafael Nadal. His digital portrayal is often clips of big emotional moments, moments of playful joy, and moments of hard emotional training/win (crying after a Grand Slam win).

Nike is still using strong storytelling tropes; passing the torch; the next era begins, but the tone is slightly lighter and more relatable. It fits Gen Z's taste for authenticity over untouchable icons. Alcaraz isn't yet marketed as a god; he's marketed as a phenomenon in the making, someone who fans can grow up with.

4.2 Adidas: The Rebels and the Progressives

Adidas, in comparison, does not build temples around its players. They frame them as agents of change. Aligning in a perfect way with Gen Z's own values around self-expression and activism in addition to emotional honesty. However, Adidas does not honour its athletes with structures that are so massive and does not declare them as top field players. They promote those athletes who proclaim change both on and off the court.

Naomi Osaka was arguably the perfect tennis ambassador for Adidas' "progressive rebel" narrative. More than her titles, it's her activism (mental health awareness, racial justice) that Adidas builds campaigns around. The content often shows her outside tournaments: speaking at events, designing her own clothing line, living her truth. Here, Adidas isn't selling tennis performance—they're selling empowerment.

4.2.1 The Rise of Relatable Icons

Adidas may not have divine legends like Nike, but what it has are imperfect heroes. The brand that we see emerging today is one that shows champions player's humanity: setbacks, vulnerability, and no small amount of laughter in real life behind the spotlight.

Adidas uses vibrant, dynamic visuals. Handheld camera work, bright colors, and all serve a single purpose: to reach that target of seeming not like an ad but like something a human might relate to "*you don't have to be perfect to be powerful"*.

Both brands find it captivating to use storytelling for staging a transition from one generation to the next. For Nike, it's about keeping the legend alive. For Adidas, it's about figuring out what even greatness means in a new world.
Athlete identities, therefore, aren't just marketing tools, they are conduits between the old tennis world and the new generation of fans that values not just achievement but authenticity.

4.3 Tournament Mythmaking: Elevating Tennis into Cultural Narratives

If athletes are considered heroes by the storytelling narrated by sports brands. Grand Slam tournaments are the theatre where stories happen, and legends are born or challenged. For brands such as Nike and Adidas, Grand Slam tournaments are not just a competitive stage, but the ideal place to create myths surrounding the players through the emotions, traditions and atmosphere brought by their athletes during the tournament, seen by millions of people. By stitching the event narratives into their digital strategies, both brands manage to deepen fan emotional loyalty and turn what are supposed to be temporary sports moments into lasting memories.

4.3.1 Wimbledon: The Temple of Tradition

In Wimbledon, Nike puts a lot of weight on its "legend" storytelling. The brand portrays Centre Court as a nearly hallowed space of tennis history. Two recent campaigns celebrating all-time greats Roger Federer and Serena Williams. Through these cinematic reels, with their muted visual palettes and stark olfactory cues (the fresh grass on Centre Court, for instance), Nike positions its athletes, past and present, as anything but ordinary. Their presence is felt like a kind of divine intervention.

At the same time, Adidas takes a less direct path. Instead of boldly confronting the time-honoured event, Adidas inserts fresh energy right into it. Through players like Tsitsipas, the brand brings mindfulness, authenticity and a cool, contemporary vibe to Wimbledon's uptight codes. The campaigns show the players in domestic moments: slow mornings in London, meditative walks around the grounds, humanising them without breaking the traditionalist framework of the tournament.

Wimbledon has embraced the digital age with sophisticated online strategies.
In using AI to produce not just highlight reels but also "personalized" moments of magic for every single viewer, the tournament allows the two primary sponsors, Nike and Adida, to push their agendas as well. Not to mention, it also allows them to do so in the digital space, where they can reach more people than ever.

4.3.2 Roland-Garros: The Cult of Grit

While Wimbledon may convey a sense of elegance, the same cannot be said for Roland Garros, which instead requires players to show resilience as they battle for the title on its red clay.

Rafael Nadal's total of 14 titles won on the clay courts of Roland Garros is beyond a tennis feat; it is a legendary sporting achievement. The Spaniard's mark on sporting history extends way beyond the boundaries of tennis. No player has ever won a Grand Slam tournament so many times, let alone the one that is considered the most physically demanding.

Adidas disrupts. It focuses on fresh faces like Alexander Zverev. Its campaigns pit Nadal's relentless domination against the energy of the new generation, suggesting that change, not permanence, is the true essence of clay.

Adidas also manage to sponsor Jo Wilfried Tsonga who was an outstanding French player and had always a powerful resonant during the French open with the crowd.

In an interesting turn, even Roland-Garros itself intensified these narratives. The TikTok strategy of the tournament, fan polls, highlight remixes, and co-created content spotlights how official organizers have become vital players in shaping the emotional trajectories of fans.

4.3.3 US Open: Urban Energy and Social Conscience

The US Open differentiates itself from other tournaments in a big way. It stands loud and proud as the only major tennis event held in the heart of a fast, furious, and utterly unapologetic urban city. The branding opportunities featured here do their best to keep up

with the frenetic pace of this urban playground. Without question, the marquee sponsors dial it up to eleven.

Adidas used Naomi Osaka to transform the US Open into a platform for significant conversations. The brand used the grand stage of the tournament to drive home a few important points. The first was that Osaka's presence on the court, and even beyond it, is something that should not just be accepted, but should be celebrated.

Unlike its competitors, Nike leaned into the street culture of New York, with all its attempts at authenticity and earnestness, it embraced some aspects of the urban experience before turning it into part of its branding. In that framing, its stars among them Frances Tiafoe and Carlos Alcaraz, with urban storytelling, with all the beats of hip-hop and the stunning mural of Roger Federer in the Bronx, that you could squeeze into it.

Once more, the tournament's very own digital strategy dovetailed perfectly with this brand storytelling. The US Open's "Spectacular Awaits" campaign, driven by collaborations with New York artists and celebrities, extended the Grand Slam into a cultural event far more profound than the matches.

4.3.4 Australian Open: The Lab of Innovation

Unlike other Grand Slam tournaments, which are steeped in history, the Australian Open presents itself as an innovator, a place where new ideas can play out. Over the past few years, Nike's efforts around the AO have leaned heavily in this direction—that's something we can also see in the treatments we gradually unpack in this piece. Futuristic visuals have come from the AO in the past, and it's probably safe to assume that they will continue.

This technology-obsessed world was reflected in the latest Adidas creations, which centered on dynamic TikTok challenges around their heat-themed kits and a big visual push into experimentation. Adidas emphasizes adaptability and heat- readiness with bold kits worn by players like Alexander Zverev during a match in the summer intensity and hot weather of Melbourne.

Most importantly, the Australian Open immerses itself in the innovation narrative. The AO has become a partner not just a backdrop to digital storytelling through AR filters, real-time fan engagement and meme-driven TikTok challenges.

Ultimately, Grand Slams are no longer just sporting events, whether it's the hallowed grass of Wimbledon, the gritty clay of Paris, the neon nights of New York or the sun-drenched innovation of Melbourne. They are living stories, and Nike and Adidas are the master storytellers. Heritage and legacy campaigns are also vitally important tools for Nike and Adidas to anchor their narratives on an emotional foundation. But those kinds of memories are reminded and reverenced not just with the kind of vintage images used by less imaginative marketers that gets right to the cultural essence and brings those images up to now, making an active part of some near-future moment in time.

The narrative layers in those three components, athlete personas, tournament storytelling, and legacy campaigns, build a strong, emotional framework for the brands' stories. Whether they're drawing on nostalgia or recent cultural shifts, Nike and Adidas are creating storytelling ecosystems that do far more than just push products. They're inviting tennis fans into stories that feel living and breathing.

4.4 Results: Social Media Platforms & Content Formats: What Drives Engagement?

4.4.1 Platform Performance Analysis

As we have seen earlier, companies such as Nike and Adidas are very skilled at using not just one, but several, layers of storytelling when employing the persona of an athlete to establish an emotional connection with their audience. Instagram, Tik-Tok and X offers distinctive tools that leverage and expand this emotional narrative. Whether or not one is familiar with the individual and his or her athletic accomplishments, is likely to have a

significant emotional connection to the narrative being told regarding that person's life and career. Moreover, a society that places such a high value on athletic prowess is one in which the emotional connection to what is being told is inherently intensified.

Instagram, celebrated for its focus on visuals, boosts engagement with carousels, Stories, and content driven by aesthetics. The visual narrative of the platform pairs well with the athlete personas, with the legendary image of Federer projected by Nike or the rebellious one of Osaka by Adidas. It makes an ideal stage for fans to see, what athletes do when they aren’t in competition.

TikTok's success is due to its capacity to leverage instant trends and challenges set by users and, most importantly, a virality driven by its all-powerful algorithm. The platform resonates particularly with the youth, who value authenticity and immediacy, aligning perfectly with the dynamic and personal athlete personas. Athletes are on TikTok for entertainment, and what they engage for further solidifying fan connections.

Twitter/X is a real-time conversation, hot take platform, and the live commentary it offers pairs perfectly with those moments in the tennis narrative when the players are courtside. It gives the fans an instant way to engage with what is happening in the tournament and makes a strong narrative hook for anyone recapping or reviewing what went down in a particular match. These platforms function not as isolated tools, but as integral extensions of the brand narratives crafted by Nike and Adidas. Their effectiveness in driving engagement is tied to the unique features of each platform and how well they work with the personas of the athletes, the storytelling of the tournaments, and the heritage campaigns of both brands to create and amplify emotional loyalty among the fans of tennis.

4.4.2 Format & Content Type Effectiveness

Although the decision of which platform to use is essential to base engagement upon, it is the content format that really sharpens interaction with fans. This means that it is not enough just to be on Instagram or TikTok, for instance; what counts is how you show up on

these platforms. By and large, the underrated dead-end for creators or platforms is becoming too static and too promotional. In any case, illustrations still reign supreme on Instagram as the most reliable way to convert people into action-minded fans, given that they are both digestible and compelling narratives about who athletes are, or as we call them, their personas(*As stated by Filo et al., 2015, video content inherently encourages higher engagement rates due to its dynamic nature and emotional impact.)*

Also, memes and user-generated content (UGC) present additional layers of relatability and spontaneity. Often humorous and easily shareable, memes are particularly at home on platforms like Twitter/X, where fast, witty fan community exchanges are at the forefront. UGC drives engagement by allowing fans to become active contributors to brand narratives, especially on Tik-Tok, where interactive trends and challenges invite a participatory culture. *(According to Alaimo & Kallinikos, 2022, user-generated content not only enhances fan involvement but also builds robust communities around shared interests.)*

How interactivity through music, editing tools, and participative features can dramatically boost engagement is well demonstrated by TikTok. The app serves as a prime example of how these elements can be used, with a built-in library of popular or trending music tracks to choose from.

4.4.3 Algorithmic Biases & Fan Behaviour Patterns

Engagement on social media sophisticatedly connects to platform-specific algorithms, and virality and visibility of content are greatly impacted. Algorithms employ engagement loops since content that is receiving earlier interactions will be further increased, and therefore the cycle tends to benefit content that is already successful. When one of my friends interacts with a post, that is the first step in an engagement loop.

Pattern of behaviour distinguishes fans across platforms. Fans engage differently across platforms, with distinctly different habits of engagement on each. Interactions on Instagram

peak around visually and aesthetically appealing posts or events. Engagement on TikTok centres around trending challenges and works best when the platform's sound motifs are used in some way. Every platform has its milestones for peak levels of activity, with Twitter's being centered around real-time events, especially matches and live announcements. Enthusiasts on fan-sharing tend to make that process more public when using TikTok and Twitter, with the two being much more 'out loud' than sharing on Instagram. Sharing on Instagram tends to maintain a slightly more private, usually through direct messaging.

Brands looking to optimize their digital marketing shouldn't ignore the political and societal biases of platforms. In essence, understanding these algorithmic biases, and the behaviours of fans are crucial for ensuring alignment with the unique ecosystems each platform presents.

5. Discussion

5.1 Observation & Key Findings from Interview with Ginevra

Observation & Key Findings from Expert Interview with Ginevra I had the chance to conduct interviews with a professional in digital marketing named Ginevra. She has very current real-world experience in the field, having worked directly at Meta in brand strategy. Ginevra's insights provided a hands-on perspective for me to consider as I explored into the work's theoretical framework, especially considering how brands associated with the sport of tennis, like Nike and Adidas, are (or are not) shifting toward more direct engagement strategies focused around the "digital fan."

Her main point was that storytelling today is the most powerful tool. She explained that audiences especially don't connect with brands through traditional ads; they connect through people and stories. Storytelling is very important. Fans now connect through

people, not ads. Platforms like Netflix show how audiences crave emotional stories over performance.

Adidas seems to understand this better than Nike, using collaborations and relatable content to bring out the human side of athletes. In contrast, Nike often leans into legacy and perfection, which may strengthen the brand image but doesn’t build the same kind of fan loyalty.

Another critical point she brought up is that brands face the obstacle of changing with the quickly evolving algorithms, especially on platforms like TikTok and Instagram. She noted that while Meta's AI isn't the "smartest," it's the most "powerful" because of its regularity. What's most important, she said, is not to produce "ads" but rather to craft shareable, interactive, short-form content that generates actual engagement. To make it differently, for example when it resembles at a one-on-one conversation with the viewer.

To conclude, the link between tennis and fashion was discussed. The Sinner x Gucci campaign was cited as an example of how tennis can be integrated into lifestyle culture, so that even people who don't like tennis can stumble across it. That kind of crossover helps push tennis deeper into the culture and expands who is emotionally engaged with it. In the end, this dialogue helped me to understand that effective fan engagement is not about targeting or pushing messages. It’s about creating moments that people care about, and letting digital platforms amplify them naturally. Brands that do this well aren’t just selling products; they’re building stories that people want to follow.

5.2 Survey Results: Exploring Fan Engagement and Perceptions of Tennis Brand Strategies on Social Media

Alongside the qualitative analysis of the digital strategies of Nike and Adidas, a brief survey was carried out among 20 university students aged between 18 and 25. The goal was to gain some preliminary insights into the interactions of the Gen Z with online brand

content, and, more specifically, the content of tennis brands. Why or how was the aim of the survey. Why do they engage? Do they engage in certain ways because of the algorithms that control the platforms they predominantly use, or the emotional loyalty they have for sports brands and their athletes? Are there preferred storytelling formats or kinds of storytelling? Do they interact differently with certain platforms because of the nature of the platforms?

Students were asked how often they engaged with those platforms, and with what level of emotional connection to the content they interacted. Perceptions of brand identity and storytelling were also probed. The practical data resulting from this questioning reflects well the key themes of my thesis. Those themes are the effectiveness of social media platforms for fan engagement and the importance of emotional response and narrative in that engagement.

The outcomes showed a few evident patterns and closely align with the two primary research questions of this thesis. Five essential findings became Clear:
The respondents used Instagram and TikTok the most, with over 80% saying they used the platforms consistently. Instagram was used for visual content that was polished and connected to the aesthetics of professional sports. TikTok was used for humor and interactivity and was seen as having a more authentic tone. Twitter/X and YouTube were paid moderate attention, and Facebook was not a part of the digital lives of these students at all. This certainly seems to confirm that Facebook is growing irrelevant with Gen Z, and that the platforms they do use are optimized for short, mobile content.

People said that their engagement with tennis content was driven by events—much of it focused on individual athletes rather than the brands themselves. Respondents said they primarily engaged with tennis content during events like Wimbledon and the French Open, and this engagement peaked during "tending moments" like major tournament finales. Even when they did not, in fact, wear tennis whites, respondents said they dressed up in Instagrammable looks for these occasions to perform. The study concluded that "performance on Instagram (and TikTok) can be considered the currency of casual fan

engagement, with trend-driven, visually satisfying posts wrapped in narratives about individual tennis players serving as the content that elicits such performance."

Across digital platforms, tennis was more closely linked with Nike than with any other brand. In storytelling, Nike was clearly perceived as the brand that was doing more and better. Some 70% of the people we spoke to remembered Nike campaigns featuring top tennis talent, Serena Williams, Roger Federer, that they found to be emotionally deep and visually powerful. By contrast, Adidas wasn't nearly as top of mind. Some of those we interviewed do appreciate the brand for its collaborations with Naomi Osaka and for having a progressive brand voice, but certainly without the same level of recognition.

The thesis' central arguments are strongly supported by the findings of the survey: that fan involvement in the digital era is platform-centered and emotionally motivated, and that the storytelling that's increasingly mediating fan involvement is preferring the kind of narrative that puts real people in the center over one that's favoring highly polished brand imagery. Successful digital storytelling by Nike is mostly because of the emotional building of resonance with its viewers through narratives centered on athletes. They take cultural icons like Serena Williams and Federer and use their stories to build not only loyalty over a long period of time but also an impressive and memorable campaign.

The greatest platforms for tennis brands to reach Gen Z are TikTok and Instagram. These two are non-negotiables when considering the most effective means of connecting with tennis's next generation of fans, for the visual and narrative opportunities they provide. But to only look at two platforms in isolation would be reductive.

The content that Gen Z audiences most strongly respond to is authentic, emotionally centered, and participatory. They love it when the content gives them a look inside the real lives of the players or invites them to interact with the content in some way, whether that's through polls, challenges, or just plain old reactions.

Today's fragmented, rapid digital landscape poses challenges for tennis brands. Clearly, we can't escape traditional marketing, but it hardly seems judicious to focus on it almost

exclusively, given how much consumer engagement has shifted to other formats. The survey provides actionable data that helps with what I hope is a more fruitful exploration of content strategy. I'd like to think this exploration is born out of the desire to help brands navigate the new engagement landscape.

Conclusion

In this thesis, I explore the degree to which and the ways in which social media can be used as a transformative tool for enhancing fan engagement in the sport of tennis. My investigation takes an especially sharp focus on one question that seems to lie at the very center of modern sports marketing:

1. *How do Nike and Adidas construct digital storytelling frameworks—through athlete personas, tournament narratives, and heritage campaigns—to foster emotional loyalty among tennis fans?*

2. *Which social media platforms and content formats drive the highest engagement for tennis brands, and how do algorithmic biases and fan behaviours shape these outcomes?*

To respond to this, the study set up two main research inquiries. The first had to do with how Nike and Adidas construct their digital storytelling—how athlete personas, tournament narratives, and brand heritage campaigns come together to forge emotional connections with fans. The core part of the research was dedicated to digging deep into the ways each brand handles digital storytelling. The second research question looked at which platforms and content formats provide the most fan engagement and how the brands in question can increase the likelihood of emotional reactions from fans by using certain platforms and formats.

In the first half of the thesis, I examined the power of the brand narrative strategy. Stories involving iconic athletes and historic tournaments are powerful engagement tools. Nike emphasises legacy and prestige (e.g. its association with Federer and Wimbledon); Adidas is more rebellious and progressive (e.g. Naomi Osaka and mental health/social justice campaigning). These differences seem to reflect each brand's deeper values and the type of emotional connection they aim to create. What both companies seem to understand, however, is that fans are no longer passive consumers; they want stories they can relate to and, ideally, participate in. Whether it's through nostalgic throwbacks or inspirational docuseries, digital storytelling becomes a tool for emotional resonance.

Moving on to the second axis of research, we focused on the specific engagement offered by each platform. Instagram, TikTok and Twitter (now X) each offer different means of achieving engagement. Different means of achieving engagement are offered by Instagram, TikTok and Twitter (now X). TikTok, on the other hand, is more effective at real-time, playful and often participatory fan engagement, especially among Gen Z - through challenges, fan interviews or impromptu behind-the-scenes snippets where TikTokers seem to be having as much fun as they are filming themselves. Meanwhile, Twitter (now X) remains the platform of choice for instant reactions and direct interaction with fans, although engagement tends to be more intense for hot takes.

Meanwhile on to the second line of research, we looked at engagement specific to each platform. For example, Instagram carousel allowed for polished aesthetic- driven storytelling that did well during big tournament. In contrast, Tik-Tok is more about real-time fan engagement and is the most playful and driver the emotion of fan especially with Gen z. This is the platform for challenges, short-form interviews, and behind-the-scenes moments that really let fan engagement sizzle. If TikTok is the playground for fan engagement, then Twitter is the fan engagement factory. What was particularly revealing in this section is how biases in algorithms shape fan interaction.

Platforms reward different types of content based on their native logic: TikTok favors authenticity and frequent posting; Instagram prizes visual cohesion and hashtags; and

Twitter is all about viral opinions. Brands that understand and master these nuances are not only more likely to be seen, but also more likely to be shared, liked and remembered. In addition, patterns in fan behaviour, such as engagement peaks during Grand Slams or preferences for interactive tools like polls and Q&As, further influence how content is tailored. Taken together, these two forces - the native logic of fan platforms and the patterns of fan behaviour - underscore the need for a flexible, platform-specific strategy that adapts not only to the somewhat random nature of their algorithmic systems, but also to real-time expectations.

The qualitative case study approach was used in this work. Its strength is that it brings depth and context to the findings. I employed a method of triangulation, drawing on social media analytics, campaign reviews, and expert interviews to find out not just what strategies were being used, but why they were (or weren't) resonating. I established in a rhythm that emotional loyalty isn't about the number of clicks or views; it's about how fans feel they're a part of something. And in tennis, where fandom is even more global and segment-oriented than in other sports, that's a pretty crucial element of the game.

This thesis concludes that social media is the main venue for fan engagement for tennis brands. Brand identity is performed on these platforms as fans congregate and as products are launched, tested, and validated. But the effectiveness of doing all this on social media is contingent upon a brand's ability to tell an authentic story that is also platform smart. Too much reliance on legacy or one-size-fits-all strategies put a brand at risk of being seen as inauthentic and, thus, irrelevant.

This means developing content not just for fans, but with fans, for practitioners. It means adapting narrative tone and format depending on the platform and using real-time data not just to optimize campaigns but to co-create culture, for practitioners. For researchers, this evolves into something new. It opens new doors into understanding how fandom evolves in digital spaces.

Finally, this thesis serves as a call for tennis brands. They must view the digital landscape not as a unit but as a collection of platforms, each one with its own vibes, each one with its own rules. In the end, the tennis brands that will be most likely to succeed aren't necessarily the ones with the most powerful voices. Instead, it will be those brands that engage thoughtfully with their core consumers, listen to them closely, and tell stories that the fans want to be part of.

Bibliography

Abeza, G., O'Reilly, N., & Seguin, B. (2019). *Social media in sport: Theory and practice*. Routledge.

Alaimo, C., & Kallinikos, J. (2022). Algorithmic affordances in digital platforms. *Social Media + Society, 8*(1). https://doi.org/10.1177/20563051221087002

DataReportal. (2024). *Global digital overview*. https://datareportal.com/reports/digital-2024-global-overview-report

Ellis, T. (2025, March 16). ATP and WTA try to net Gen Z: How tennis is targeting digital natives. *Forbes*. https://www.forbes.com/sites/timellis/2025/03/16/atp-and-wta-try-to-net-gen-z-how-tennis-is-targeting-digital-natives/

Filo, K., Lock, D., & Karg, A. (2015). Sport and social media research. *Journal of Sport Management, 29*(1), 1–10. https://doi.org/10.1123/jsm.2013-0296

Hootsuite. (2023). *TikTok marketing guide*. https://blog.hootsuite.com/tiktok-marketing/

Hutchins, B., & Rowe, D. (2012). *Sport beyond television: The internet, digital media and the rise of networked media sport*. Routledge.

Kassing, J. W., Billings, A. C., & Brown, K. A. (2020). Communicating fast and faithfully: Twitter's role in sustaining sports fan engagement. *International Journal of Sport Communication, 13*(3), 345–358.

Marketing Week. (2024). Adidas marketing effectiveness report. https://www.marketingweek.com/adidas-marketing-effectiveness/

YourSocialStrategy. (2023). Understanding Nike's social media strategy: Why it works. *Medium*. https://yoursocialstrategy.medium.com/understanding-nikes-social-media-strategy-why-it-works-88f9cba69182

ATP. (2024). ATP announces record social digital audience growth. https://www.atptour.com/en/news/atp-announces-record-social-digital-audience-growth-2024

Appendix

Interview Transcrits

Ginevra: If you go on LinkedIn and search for Nike, you'll find quite a few good articles about how Nike is currently losing ground to Adidas—especially in terms of fandom and authenticity. They've kind of lost the voice they used to have.

Mattéo: You mean those iconic Nike commercials?

Ginevra: Exactly. You were talking about those 90-second TV ads that felt more like cinematic short films. They were amazing. But now, Nike is really struggling to translate that same storytelling power into the digital space. They haven't found a voice that resonates with their audience in a consistent or authentic way.

Mattéo: So, what would you say are the key things that matter most in digital engagement?

Ginevra: The first and most important one is probably *community*. If you're trying to build emotional engagement, that comes from creating a real connection. And Nike is currently having a hard time identifying the right communities to engage with authentically.

They did go through phases—like focusing on the Black community and on basketball—but they often misused the creators and spokespeople they worked with. It felt more like exploitation than real collaboration.

Mattéo: Do you have an example?

Ginevra: Yes, there's a well-known case where a designer named Dean built a shoe for Nike, and then publicly went on social media to say he couldn't endorse it because he didn't feel it was right. That really damaged trust. So yeah, Nike has some serious challenges when it comes to connecting meaningfully with communities today.

Interview Transcript – Ginevra (Part 2)

Mattéo: From your perspective, what has Adidas done really well when it comes to fan engagement through social media?

Ginevra: One thing Adidas has done brilliantly is its collaborations. If we look at sports in general, Adidas is winning emotionally through highly selective and smart partnerships—whether in fashion, sports, or mixed-community projects. They've really succeeded in blending the fashion and sports industries.

Mattéo: Do you have a specific example?

Ginevra: Yes, I remember one football jersey they did in collaboration with Stüssy and Gucci. That one really stood out. They've also worked with names like Emilio André. They've done a lot, actually.

What this shows is that Adidas has built a strong content strategy. I'm not sure if you're familiar with their internal setup, but they have what's called the "Newsroom." It's quite a good system.

Mattéo: I've heard a bit about it. How does it work?

Ginevra: The Newsroom helps them centralize and manage digital communications. Now, they are a bit slow sometimes—I've worked with them, and it can be difficult to move things along—but they have a solid understanding of a concept that's gaining traction: "Creative is the new targeting."

Mattéo: Right, I've come across that idea.

Ginevra: The idea is that instead of doing hyper-targeted ads based on demographics or interests, you produce a wide variety of creative content, distribute it broadly across social platforms, and let the algorithm do the work. It finds the right audience for each piece of content. That approach tends to perform better than traditional interest-based targeting.

And it works especially well in fashion-driven markets because the audience is usually diverse, with multiple interests. So the more varied your collaborations, the more communities you touch—and those communities start talking about you. It amplifies your engagement organically.

Mattéo: That's a smart approach.

Ginevra: Yes, and this is where Adidas has the edge. Nike is just starting to open up in that area. They've begun experimenting with similar strategies, but Adidas has been doing this for a while—and doing it well.

Ginevra: So, Nike has started to open up a bit recently. I think they realized, "Okay, we've lost a lot of money." And now they're trying to course-correct.

Mattéo: You mean through better storytelling?

Ginevra: Exactly. They need to improve their storytelling. I understand what your mentor said about your thesis being focused on a niche, but the reality is that the best practices you use in tennis are often the same ones you use in any other sport.

Mattéo: That's true. But tennis still feels a bit different, doesn't it?

Ginevra: Yes, it is different. In tennis, for fan engagement, brands can't rely on a team identity or a logo the way they do in football or basketball. They have to build everything around individual personalities. So when they create an ad for someone like Sinner or Alcaraz, they need to craft a specific story about that player—something that fans can emotionally connect with.

Like, for example, when people think about Nadal hitting the ball with pure intensity—there's a whole vision and emotion that comes with that. But the problem with Nike right now is that their vision has become too focused on *excellence*. They position their athletes like Alcaraz as the "new king," which might work for brand prestige, but it doesn't necessarily help bring in new audiences or drive actual sales.

Mattéo: So it's more about image than engagement?

Ginevra: Exactly. On the other hand, Adidas is doing something different. Their campaigns feel more *approachable*. They make friendly content that feels like they're

actually talking with the players, not just showcasing them. And that makes a difference in terms of emotional connection.

Mattéo: Yeah, that's a really good point.

Ginevra: So I agree with you… well, yes and no. Because here's the thing: you have to think about how the *digital marketing funnel* works.

Mattéo: Right, awareness and all that?

Ginevra: Yes. You start with awareness. On digital platforms, that means someone sees your content, the algorithm picks up on their interest, and then starts building impressions. From there, they get targeted again—but this time with content aimed at *consideration* and then *conversion*.

So if you don't do that awareness phase right—if the first impression isn't strong or engaging—the algorithm won't even push your next piece of content. That's a big issue. And Nike isn't always getting that awareness part right, which messes up the whole funnel.

Ginevra: Storytelling around athletes has become really powerful. It's one of the most engaging things right now. For instance, Netflix created an entire series about tennis, and that generated a huge spike in interest for the sport.

Mattéo: Yeah, I noticed that too. Same thing they did with Formula 1, right?

Ginevra: Exactly—Formula 1 exploded because of it, and tennis is following a similar path, just on a smaller scale. What you said earlier is right: Adidas is doing a great job showing the *human* side of players. It's not just about athletic performance anymore—it's about storytelling.

Nowadays, it's often more effective to create content rather than traditional ads when it comes to engaging fans, especially in tennis. Even if someone isn't a die-hard fan, if they see someone like Sinner in a more personal, human light—like hearing that he used to be a skier or that he lost his aunt—that builds emotional relatability.

Mattéo: So people connect more with the story than just the sport?

Ginevra: Exactly. That's the power of emotional storytelling. But there's also a danger: fans might get interested in the story and the player, but not necessarily in the product being

promoted. That's the challenge for brands—creating meaningful content while still landing on product messaging.

If we talk about what works best on social media today, it's often short-form content—one-minute videos, six-second stories, even quick audio hooks designed for the algorithm. But here's the interesting part: when I worked at Meta, we found that if the content is *really good*, people will still watch longer videos—even up to five minutes.

Mattéo: So it's more about quality than just duration?

Ginevra: Exactly. The content just has to be *worth it*. If it's relevant, emotional, or captivating, people stay—even if it's long. But yes, short and sharp still tends to perform better in general.

Mattéo: As someone who worked at Meta, can I ask you something specific? When it comes to KPIs, can we consider shares or tags as reliable indicators of *fan loyalty*, or are they just short-term signals?

Ginevra: Great question. So, no—shares and tags alone aren't long-term indicators of loyalty. But they are very important. At Meta, the main KPI for content performance was *shareability*. Any form of interaction—sharing, tagging, commenting—is considered a higher level of engagement than just impressions.

An impression just means the content appeared on your screen. But maybe you were talking to someone and didn't even notice it. That still counts as a view. It's very passive.

Mattéo: Right, so real engagement comes from actions.

Ginevra: Yes. When someone interacts—shares it, rewatches it, shows it to someone else—the algorithm picks that up as real interest. And the algorithm isn't just looking at one factor. It considers multiple dimensions: how long you watched, whether you replayed it, what song was in it, whether a person was featured, what the topic was, and so on.

All of that gets logged. Then it starts feeding you more content—maybe not the same content, but content with similar elements. That's how the AI keeps refining what it shows you.

Mattéo: That's actually really fascinating.

Ginevra: It is! And something to include in your thesis: the algorithm is retuned roughly every six months. So what works *now* won't necessarily work six months from now. It's constantly evolving, and that keeps things both challenging and exciting for marketers.

Ginevra: So, the main objective of Meta is to feed its AI. Now, Meta's AI is not necessarily the most advanced—OpenAI is better, Entropic is better—but the difference is that Meta has the *largest reach* in the world.

Mattéo: Because of all the platforms?

Ginevra: Exactly. When you combine Facebook, Instagram, and WhatsApp, Meta reaches over four billion active users globally. That reach gives it a huge advantage. The way AI works is that it needs to be "fed"—the more data, the better it gets. So Meta constantly adjusts its algorithms to learn more and keep improving its AI.

Mattéo: That makes sense.

Ginevra: Now, tying this back to marketing—especially in a niche sport like tennis—it's really difficult for a brand to stay updated with how each platform's algorithm works. So instead of trying to "hack" the system, brands should rely on best practices that center around *human connection*.

That means creating *authentic storytelling*, not just ads. It's also about personalization and content that resonates emotionally. When you're a brand, what really matters is how much interaction you're generating with your audience.

Mattéo: That fits with what we were saying earlier about emotional engagement.

Ginevra: Exactly. Now, beyond Meta, I've been working a lot with TikTok recently. TikTok operates a bit differently—it's very affiliate-driven. They have strong brand partnerships and work with a massive number of creators. These creators build content alongside your brand, making it feel natural and community-based.

Mattéo: Like influencer collaborations?

Ginevra: Yes, and they can be even more effective than traditional brand campaigns. We talked before about Adidas working with Gucci, Stüssy, Emilio André—but the most

powerful collaborations are often with *real people* who have influence in *local markets*. That's where the real traction happens.

There's also the editorial side—partnering with fashion magazines, for instance, that might highlight how Kylie Jenner wore an Adidas piece. That's huge for fashion, of course.

Mattéo: But in tennis?

Ginevra: Right—let's bring it back to tennis. Fashion still plays a big role. One of the biggest recent campaigns featured Jannik Sinner wearing Gucci—with the bag and everything. That was a big moment.

What's interesting for you in your thesis is how tennis brands have started embracing *cross-industry collaborations*—especially with fashion—to build deeper emotional connections. It pulls in audiences who may not have been interested in tennis before.

Mattéo: Yeah, I've noticed that too.

Ginevra: And honestly, tennis had lost a lot of fan interest over the last decade. But thanks to digital marketing—and the way it connects with Gen Z—the sport is experiencing a kind of revival. Even the rise of paddle tennis, which is closely related, has helped attract more young viewers who are now also watching tennis again.

Appendix Survey Question

1. What is your age?
    - Under 18
    - 18–20
    - 21–23
    - 24–26
    - 27+
2. Are you a tennis fan?
    - Yes
    - Casual follower
    - No
3. Which social media platforms do you use regularly? *(Select all that apply)*
    - Instagram
    - TikTok
    - Twitter/X
    - YouTube
    - Snapchat
    - Facebook
    - Other (please specify)

4. How often do you engage with tennis-related content on social media?
    - Daily
    - A few times a week
    - Occasionally
    - Rarely
    - Never
5. On which platform do you see the most engaging tennis content?
    - Instagram
    - TikTok
    - Twitter/X
    - YouTube
    - Other (please specify)
6. When do you typically engage with tennis content?
    - During tournaments (e.g., Roland-Garros, Wimbledon)
    - When a favorite player posts
    - When there's brand content (e.g., Nike, Adidas ads)
    - I don't follow tennis content specifically

7. Which brand do you associate more with tennis content online?

    - Nike
    - Adidas
    - Both equally
    - Neither

8. Do you think Nike or Adidas uses more creative storytelling in their tennis campaigns? (e.g., player personality, heritage, behind-the-scenes)
    - Nike
    - Adidas
    - Both
    - Not sure
9. (Open-ended) In your opinion, what makes a brand's tennis content emotionally engaging?
10. (Open-ended) Can you recall a tennis-related post or campaign from Nike or Adidas that caught your attention? What stood out to you?

11. Which content types do you find most engaging from tennis brands? *(Select up to 2)*

- Short videos (TikToks/Reels)
- Image carousels
- Behind-the-scenes clips
- Athlete Q&As
- Polls & interactive stories
- Memes or humorous posts

12. Do you feel that short-form content (like TikTok) is more effective than traditional posts in keeping you engaged with a brand?

- Strongly agree
- Agree
- Neutral
- Disagree
- Strongly disagree

13. (Open-ended) What advice would you give to tennis brands trying to better connect with Gen Z on social media?

ESCP Business School

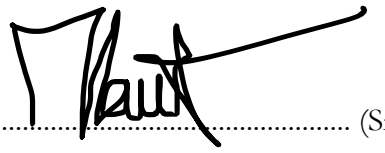
I, the undersigned, do hereby state that I have not plagiarised the paper enclosed and that I am the only author of all sentences within this text. Any sentence included which was written by another author was placed within quotation marks, with explicit indication of its source, including those generated through Artificial Intelligence tools (including Large Language Models). I am aware that by contravening the stated ESCP Business School rules on plagiarism, I break the recognised academic principles and I expose myself to sanctions upon which the disciplinary committee will decide.

I also confirm this work has not previously been submitted during studies prior to ESCP Business School. The thesis has not been presented to any other examining body, nor has it been published in whole or in part. If this work has been written during studies conducted in parallel to my time at ESCP Business School, I must state it.

Hereby, I confirm that I will not give or sell this thesis for publication to any institution. Furthermore, I will not publish this thesis on the Internet. In the case that I plan to publish this thesis, I can only do so with the written consent of my supervisor.

I grant ESCP Business School the right to use the thesis for the purpose of marking and assessing it. This right to use the thesis includes the right of ESCP Business School to commission a third party to undertake the plagiarism check on behalf of the School. The third party is subject to the same legal requirements on data protection and confidentiality as ESCP Business School.

I accept full responsibility for the content of this paper.



..... (Signature)

.....Mattéo Laurent ..... (Print name)

.....04/05/2025..... (Day/month/year)

Statement on the use of generative AI or AI-enabled technologies in the writing process

There are numerous AI or AI-enabled technologies, including generative AI such as ChatGPT, available for writing academic papers. ESCP Business School allows the use of these technologies in the preparation of written academic work, but it does not accept that AI-generated content is adopted and unedited unreflectively. The primary source should always be cited using academic referencing standards. Students are solely responsible for the accuracy and correctness of their work, including the primary sources used.

AI-generated content will not be considered original scientific work by the student submitting it. Adoption of this content without reference to its origin will be interpreted as academic misconduct. Additionally, all prompts must be saved when using generative AI-tools (e.g., ChatGPT, Gemini, Bard). Exempt from this rule are tools that focus on translations and on checking grammar, spelling, or formatting of references (e.g. Grammarly, DeepL, QuillBot). However, their use must still be documented.

Please select the answer options that apply to you in the context of writing this thesis, and specify the tools and usage in the table below:

☐ I did not use generative AI or AI-enabled technologies.

☐ I used generative AI or AI-enabled technologies only for translation and grammar, spelling, or reference checking.

☑ I used generative AI or AI-enabled technologies beyond translation and grammar, spelling, or reference checking during the writing of this paper (for example, to develop ideas or to obtain counterarguments or different perspectives). I specified the technologies and their use on the next page.

Moreover, I hereby declare that

☑ after using this/these tool(s), I have reviewed and edited the content and take full responsibility for the related sections in my paper.

☑ I saved the prompts used while writing this thesis and am willing to share my list of prompts upon request.

Mattéo Laurent
05/05/2025

Date, Name, Signature

Table of usage of AI or AI-enabled technologies

Name of student:	Mattéo Laurent
Name of tool	**Reason for usage**
Restream	Transcript Audio from Interview
Deepl	Translating some sentences
Consensus	To find some accurate Links for research